

The Devil's Kitchen of Van Houten

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Abstract—Near the ghost town of Van Houten, located in Colfax County, New Mexico, there is a natural wonder of a 'eternal flame' that is fed by a vent of gas that has been flowing for over a century. During the years of the ghost town, this was used as a picnic area and is close enough to the town to provide easy access. For many years, the exact location of the Devil's Kitchen was unknown, but after numerous expeditions, it has finally been rediscovered. This report seeks to accumulate all information about the source and to accurately record the present location for future researchers.

Index Terms—Van Houten, Willow Coal Camp, Devil's Kitchen, Eternal Flame, Raton, Colfax, Maxwell Land Grant, New Mexico, Archaeology, History

I. INTRODUCTION

Because of its importance as a recreational area for picnics, and the stories surrounding it, the Devil's Kitchen is a location of great cultural significance for the town of Van Houten. It also is a phenomenon of interest for its geological value, being one of few naturally occurring eternal flames fueled by gas.

This paper accumulates records of past publications and expeditions in search of the Devil's Kitchen, and provides cultural stories of the region. This was achieved through much work of the Counselor Staff of the NRA Whittington Center Adventure camp. This papers novel contributions to research involving the Devil's Kitchen include:

- Synthesis of all known published information and oral histories.
- Explanation of previous expeditions searching for the Devil's Kitchen, including a retrospective analysis of their successes.
- Precise location data from the Devil's Kitchen, that it may not be lost again.
- Advancement of the cultural richness of Van Houten.

Our goal is to provide an encompassing record of the Devil's Kitchen Eternal Flame that includes its history, cultural relevancy, location to familiarize a researchers of Van Houten with the natural occurrence and to deepen their connection with the ghost town.

II. RELATED WORK

The relevant related work shall be divided by that which was published when the location was still known, and previous work regarding recent expeditions. *Most of this section is excerpted from [1], with several new additions.*

A. Published References

The Devil's Kitchen is described in [2] & [6] as a ten by thirty foot area of hard, blackened earth, which resembles charcoal. [2], [3], & [6] state that activity on the surface of this area can reignite the flames in the place where the disturbance was made, with the unique trait of being able to write in flaming letters. Alternatively, [4] describes that one can scuff the ground to allow the flow of gas and light it with a match, upon which it will burn for some time before self-extinguishing.

The source of the eternal flame is believed by [2], [3], [6] & [7] to be natural gas, and [4] specifies it as methane. [2] & [5] assert that a gas well may have been built on the site at one point.

By roads, [2] puts its position a half mile from Van Houten, or by other means South of Raton ten miles on U.S. 85 (I-25), and west six miles on an unspecified company road. It is described as one mile from Van Houten in [6]. Contrarily, [3] states that it is one and a half miles from Van Houten.

As for precise location, [4] states that it is on the side of a hill, directly above the targets at the back of a range. Geographically, [5] places it at the outlet of Windmill (Willow) Canyon between the site of the old windmill and the Post Office, outside or shortly within the treeline of Star Mountain. Another source, [7], states that the location of the vent is near the point of the mesa in the fork of Willow Creek.

Stories in [4] & [6] claim that the Devil's Kitchen was used as a picnic area, and [2] & [3] specify that it was particularly the favorite of youths. Uncited cultural sources attribute the name of the nearby "Ghost Hill" to the Devil's Kitchen. It is said that the schoolchildren of Van Houten would wander onto the hill while their parents picnicked at the Kitchen. An additional cultural story from Alice Bullock is recorded in [2], of early pioneers fired upon pursuing hostile Indians and hit the Devil's Kitchen by chance. This caused the flames to reignite and leap up, making the Indians believe the pioneers had favor with the "Great Spirits." Another account by the same relator is described in [6], where a pioneer (bef. 1849) is fleeing from Indians with whom he had lost favor. He accidentally builds a campfire directly upon the Devil's Kitchen and decides to use the natural properties to convince the Indians of his magical abilities.

The fire was most recently reported to be actively burning

in 1937 in [2], although this does not necessarily indicate dormancy.

B. Previous Expeditions

The previous pedigree of expeditions may be found in Table I.

TABLE I
PAST EXPEDITIONS

Year	Members	Description
Bef. 2023	T. Barraclough, K. J. Martin, etc.	Winter hike looking for melted snow. Area west of Ghost Hill. No signs discovered. <i>In retrospect, this expedition may have been close to finding the kitchen, but it is not actively burning, so there would be no melted snow.</i>
Bef. 2023	T. Barraclough, K. J. Martin, K. Tripp	Hike on the south side of the Primitive Campground. <i>In retrospect, the expedition was in the wrong region.</i>
6/6/'23	K. Brennan	A morning hike behind Star Range on Star Mountain, with a descent onto Coors Range by way of the riverbed in the northwestern corner of the range. Near the source of the riverbed, gas was smelled. <i>In retrospect, this was the first evidence of the Devil's Kitchen that was found, although the precise location was not discovered</i>
6/21/'24	K. Brennan, C. Greenland, K. J. Martin, D. Nelson	An expedition of the field on the west side of the Coors range was made. A brick was found in the NW riverbed but no gas was smelled. <i>In retrospect, this expedition was very close to the actual location, although nothing was discovered.</i>
6/29/'24	K. Brennan, M. Hecker	A wide reaching expedition was made, encompassing the Coors Range, NW riverbed, the northern fields behind the Coors range, and the eastern side of Star Mountain. No relevant discoveries were made. <i>In retrospect, the expedition was too far North to discover the Kitchen.</i>
12/30/'24	K. Brennan, D. Nelson, E. Kippenberger, L. Nelson, J. Boley	An expedition starting at the NW riverbed that encompassed the entire base and summit of Ghost Hill. <i>In retrospect, this expedition was very close to the actual location, although nothing was discovered.</i>
6/19/'25	K. Brennan, M. Hecker	A night walk along the western side of Coors range yielded a strong natural gas scent. <i>In retrospect, this occurred at the area about 100 ft to the northwest of the kitchen, and allowed a smaller search area based on this and the other gas scent to be defined.</i>
6/'25	C. Greenland, D. Nelson	Expedition south of primitive campground, near the area of Tres Fuentes. <i>In retrospect, the expedition was in the wrong region.</i>
7/3/'25	M. Lawless, et al.	Discovery of the Kitchen, explained in this paper.

III. ACCOUNT OF THE DISCOVERY

One night, Mason Lawless was driving his truck on the west side of the Coors Range. Either in turning around on the road, or otherwise coming slightly off of the defined path, he ran directly over the Devil's Kitchen. The additional pressure from

his truck released a large amount of gas into the air, which he smelled. He was unaware at the time of the existence of the Devil's Kitchen, so he did not investigate.

On the second night of Banquet for the 2025 year (7/3/2025), a group of the counselors including Mason Lawless were walking around on the Coors Range during the dance at night. By chance, they ran into Mark Hecker and Kelcey Martin on a walk. Mark informed them that they were in the region of the Devil's Kitchen, and if they smelled gas to let him know. Mason immediately noted that he had smelled gas in an area nearby a few days before (recounting the truck story). The correlation was immediately made, and a search party of the counselors with Mason went to find the area.

After about 15 minutes of searching, the area was rediscovered, and a gas smell was clearly present. A great crowd of witnesses was gathered, including the vast majority of the 2025 counselor staff (notably: Delaney Nelson, Cody Greenland, Mason Lawless, Kendrick Martin, and many more). Guests present included Kai Brennan, Mark Hecker, and Kelcey Martin, as well as Tucker Barraclough by facetime. The ground was black, as described, and no plants grew on the Kitchen. It had rained that night, so the ground was damp, which may have partially reduced the flow of gas. Shovels were quickly procured to break the ground, and a small excavation was made. As the digging continued, the smell of gas was extreme, and witnesses coming up later remarked that as they walked upwind "it smelled like someone had released an entire tank of propane."

The excavation resulted in several bore holes about 2 feet in diameter and 2 feet deep. The great depth and width were not necessary to start the flow of gas, but the holes were made with zeal, and it certainly aided the flow and accumulation of gas in the bases of the holes. Upon the introduction of the flame of a lighter, the gas would ignite with a blue flame and chase the gas back into the ground before extinguishing. For deeper holes that got beyond the wet ground, the gas would continue burning at the bottom of the holes for minutes, and the flow of gas was plainly visible from the dancing flames.

Great jubilation was had that night with festivities that surely recalled those held by the citizens of Van Houten at that very place. A still image showing the burning gas in one of the deeper holes is depicted in fig. 1.

The gas had a distinct smell. No explanation of the scent was necessary because everyone instinctively understood that the origin was natural gas. The ground in the area did not seem as hard as previous accounts had described. It is a patch of black earth, with small grains and clumps of black material. It almost appears like very uniform broken down coal grains, despite the fact that it is significantly lower than 7000 ft in elevation (thus there should be no coal in the region). The black material smells like tar or oil and is permanently infused with the scent of gas.

After the discovery of the Kitchen was confirmed and all witnesses were satisfied, the excavation holes were filled and the spot was marked on various GPS tools.



Fig. 1. Still image from a video of the Devil's Kitchen's on the night of discovery.

IV. LOCATION

The map in fig. 2 depicts the area discovered and excavated on the 3rd of July, 2025 as point "A". The coordinates of the excavation were (36.791046, -104.546250).

It is unclear whether point "B" is also a part of the Devil's Kitchen, for it was not explored that night, but it has the same appearance on aerial imagery.

It is plainly visible from the discovery that all of the sources describe this area, and that all accounts are accurate.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

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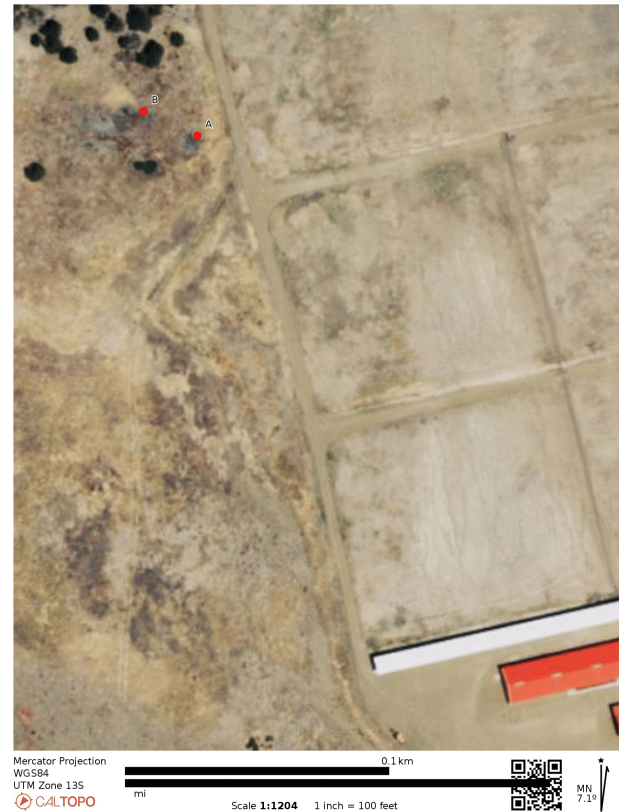


Fig. 2. Aerial imagery map of the Devil's Kitchen and surroundings.

Houten's history, including Tucker Barraclough, George 'Judo' Yaksich, Markus Aurelius Hecker, Mike Ballew, H. B. Nickelson, the employees of the NRA Whittington Center, many others from the past, and those yet to come.

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